Prerequisite knowledge checks

Identifying the foundations for new learning

Use this before new teaching when students need specific existing knowledge to access the explanation. Check the actual prerequisite rather than asking whether students remember last lesson.

How to do it well

1 Identify the prerequisite. Name the small piece of knowledge or process that students must retrieve before the new content can make sense.

2 Elicit it from everyone. Use a short atomised question, mini-whiteboards, call and response or a brief written response. Check competence, not confidence.

3 State the connection. Explain how the new learning builds on what students already know; highlight similarities and differences.

4 Start broad, then narrow. Give the general concept or organising idea before introducing detail.

5 Make students process the link. Use self-explanation, Turn and Talk or a comparison prompt so pupils articulate the connection themselves.

6 Check meaning and revisit. Probe how ideas connect, address weak links, and return to the concept later so the connection remains accessible.

What this sounds like

“Before we explain ionic formulae, show me the charge on a magnesium ion and a chloride ion. Keep your answers private until the signal.”

Classroom example. Before teaching ionic formulae, a Chemistry teacher checks ion charges on boards. Several pupils remember the symbols but confuse charges. The teacher repairs that small prerequisite and checks another pair of ions before modelling charge balance. The new explanation now starts from knowledge the class has shown it can use.

Top tips that make the technique work

Atomise the check. Test a small prerequisite directly, rather than hiding it inside a complex question that makes failure hard to interpret.

Separate recall from application. A remembered definition does not automatically establish that students can use it.

Choose a consequential prerequisite. Check the knowledge that would block today’s learning, not everything previously taught.

Fix the gap before adding complexity. A brief model and a fresh check may be more useful than continuing over an insecure foundation.

Keep the BSCS boundary clear. Spaced retrieval belongs in Do Now; the immediate prerequisite check sits at the opening of Explain.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Gather independent responses before introducing the new demand.	Inferring readiness from confident volunteers.
Make the connection to new learning explicit.	Repeating an entire previous lesson when one component needs repair.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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